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A Linguistic Note on the Segmentation of *eseakaíi*

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Abstract

This note proposes a cautious linguistic analysis of the sequence *eseakaíi*, attested in a recently published Palaeohispanic inscription. The aim is not to provide a global interpretation of the document, but to show that a simple segmentation based on well-attested mechanisms of historical Basque has not yet been considered in the published literature. The proposal advanced here relies exclusively on internal Basque evidence, without recourse to external comparisons or speculative reconstructions. Two independent palaeographic arguments demonstrate that the correct segmentation is *ese-akari*, not *eseak-ari*. The resulting form aligns with a productive Basque derivational suffix *-akari*, yielding a semantically natural interpretation.

1 Context

The critical edition of the inscription was provided by Aiestaran, Gorrochategui & Velaza (2023), who establish the diplomatic reading and palaeographic description. The third line contains the sequence:

oTírtan · eseakaíi

Most interpretations published so far attempt to analyse these forms within a proto-Vasconic or para-Iberian framework, often relying on external comparisons or hypothetical morphological reconstructions. The present note simply argues that an internally motivated Basque reading is also possible, and in fact palaeographically required.

2 Dialectological Background: *eseak egin*

The expression *eseak egin* is well attested in Basque dialectal tradition, with meanings such as “to make S-shapes”, “to zigzag”, “to stagger”, or “to walk unsteadily”. Representative examples include:

- “*Eseak egin, hacer eses el borracho*” (LE-Ir., 164).
- “*Mutikuak bizikletan, egundoko esiak egiñaz...*” (Elexp. Berg.).
- “*Ikusten nuen Gillermo [...] suge bat zirudiela ese asko egitean.*” (AB AmaE 394).
- “*Eseak zabuka egiñaz...*” (Urruz Urz 118).
- “*Balantz edo ese*” (Otañ 77, ap. ELok 515).

The nominal base *ese* / *eseak* thus denotes an oscillating or unstable movement and can serve as a derivational base in historical Basque morphology.

3 Palaeographic Arguments for the Segmentation *ese-akari*

Two independent palaeographic observations demonstrate that the sequence *eseakari* must be segmented as *ese-akari*.

1. The KA sign is a single, indivisible grapheme

In the Levantine Palaeohispanic script, the syllable *KA* is written with a single grapheme. It cannot be decomposed into a consonantal *k* followed by a vowel *a*. Consequently, the sequence *-ka-* in *eseakari* is graphically indivisible. Any segmentation of the form *esea-k-ari* ($\rightarrow$ *eseak-ari*) is palaeographically impossible, as it would require a separation between *k* and *a* that the script does not permit.

2. A visible spacing separates *ese* and *akari*

Inspection of the bronze hand reveals a clear spacing between the group of signs *e-s-e* and the following group *a-ka-r-i*. This spacing marks a word boundary and directly supports the segmentation:

ese akari

This second argument is independent of the first: even if the KA sign were segmentable (it is not), the visible spacing would still impose the division *ese-akari*.

4 Morphological Analysis: the Suffix *-akari*

The suffix *-akari* is well attested in several Basque dialects (e.g. *zorhakari*, *sorokari*, *zorkari*, *soakai*), with the meaning:

“individual characterised by a repeated action or habitual behaviour.”

It is a single derivational unit, not analyzable as *-ak + ari*. The segmentation *ese-akari* therefore aligns perfectly with Basque derivational morphology.

5 Semantic Interpretation

The base *ese* (“zigzag”, “S-shaped movement”; cf. *eseak egin* “to zigzag, to stagger”) combined with the habitual suffix *-akari* yields:

ese-akari = “one who habitually zigzags or staggers”, “the unsteady one”.

This interpretation is semantically natural and requires no speculative reconstruction.

6 Scope and Limitations

This proposal does not aim to solve the entire inscription nor to provide a global translation. It simply shows that the sequence *eseakari* can be interpreted using real Basque material, and that the palaeography itself requires the segmentation *ese-akari*. The analysis is conservative, internally motivated, and avoids speculative proto-Vasconic reconstructions.

References

Aiestaran, M., Gorrochategui, J. & Velaza, J. (2023). *La inscripción vascónica de Irulegi (Valle de Aranguren, Navarra)*. *Palaeohispanica* 23, 267–293. <https://doi.org/10.36707/PALAEHISPANICA.V23IO.560>